Where to Begin When the Care Is Working, More or Less

Three first moves, in order, and what can wait.

You look after your husband, and it works, more or less. The kids help when they can. Nothing in particular has happened, which is exactly why it's hard to know where to start looking.

Start here. Three things, in this order, with no clock on any of them.

1

Write down your week

List what you do for your husband in a typical week, including the things that don't feel like care: setting out his pills, the driving, the calls to the doctor's office, the bills. Beside each one, note whether it's new or has changed in the last year. [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST The list grew one task at a time, so nobody has seen it whole, you included. The next two moves both start from it.

2

Ask each person for one concern

Ask your husband first, then your daughter and the other kids, and anyone else who helps: what's one thing on your mind about how this is going? One each, written down in that person's own words. Then add your own. The National Institute on Aging says the best way to know what someone needs is to ask them directly, and notes that a primary caregiver, especially a spouse, may be hesitant to ask for help. [2] [3]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST One concern is small enough to answer honestly, and when everyone is asked, saying what's hard becomes an ordinary thing to do. That goes for you too.

3

Put one conversation on the calendar

Look over the concerns and pick the unresolved one that matters most to the family. Choose a day, and tell everyone ahead of time what the one subject is. While you're setting it up, ask one more thing: when something new comes up, how should any of us raise it? You're only arranging the conversation. Having it comes later. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests a narrow focus for each family meeting, and the National Institute on Aging says these talks are most productive when there is not an emergency. [4] [3]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST A conversation with a date and one subject is easier to have than one that waits for the right moment.

What can wait

- Whether your husband needs more help than he has now, or a different kind.
- Who in the family ought to be doing what.
- Settling the subject you've put on the calendar. For now it only needs a date.
- What it all adds up to. That takes a fuller look at his situation with people who can see the whole picture, and your written week is what makes it a good one.

One thing that isn't a list item

A worry about your husband's health doesn't have to wait for a family conversation. The National Institute on Aging suggests a visit to a health care provider when you're concerned about a person's physical or mental health, and says you might offer to make the appointment or go along.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't judge how the arrangement is going, say whether your husband needs more help, or decide anything. It puts three first moves in order.

Ready for the next step?

You've got your week on paper, one concern from each person and a conversation on the calendar. The care interview takes it from there: it walks you through your husband's needs and the help around him area by area, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The kinds of tasks to list follow the National Institute on Aging's description of caregiving. The advice to ask a person directly, to talk when there is no emergency and to see a health care provider about a health concern is the National Institute on Aging's. Keeping a family meeting to a narrow focus is the Family Caregiver Alliance's. The three moves and their order are ours.

1. National Institute on Aging, Getting Started With Caregiving
2. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
3. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting